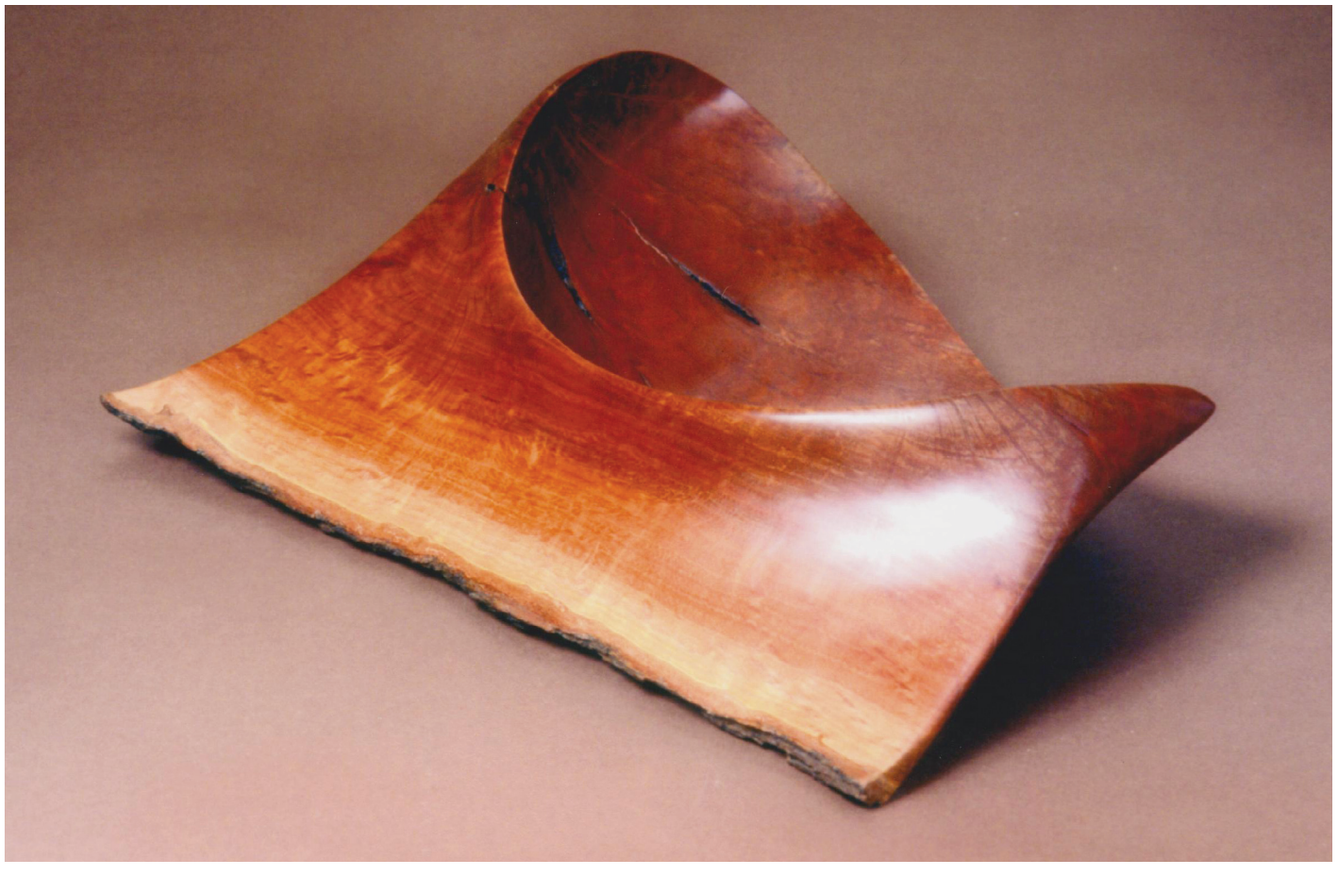

'Container Series' in blackwood, silver ash and red gum. Finished with U-Beaut Shellawax Glow and Traditional Wax. 135 x 120 x 80mm

your individual lathe, for example, Clarke's following systems and steady rest with laser. Clarke tools also supply another system by Trent Bosch – USA. This allows turners to achieve quite thin walls and much taller pieces through narrow openings.

Drying techniques

The process of drying green wood by air, kiln, microwaving or freezing and then placing into a refrigerator to dry it to a satisfactory moisture content, has developed in the last 30 years.

The freezing of wood – up to 24 hours in a freezer – is now being used by woodturners, enabling them to use larger and odd sections of wood. You can start with a full section of wood then part turn to possible shape – thicker – to allow for the final piece. After the process – freezer to refrigerator – has removed most of the moisture, weigh the wood every two days. Depending on the density of the wood it should stay up to four weeks in the refrigerator. The piece can then be turned to final shape and finished on the lathe. You have two options with a green section of wood:

1. Turn the piece down to the desired shape, dry the surface with a propane torch or heat gun, then sand to finish level and apply a coat of oil. Remove from the lathe and finish the base, wrap it in plastic and place in the freezer for 24 hours until frozen. Remove and thaw out, then place in the refrigerator for three to five weeks. Weigh until the weight remains consistent. Our level moisture content is 12.5%, weight loss depends on density.
2. Part turn a large section of wood to about 25–32mm the thickness of the final bowl shape, then go through the freezing/refrigerator process. Obviously the process will take longer because the wood is thicker; trial and error with different structured woods is evident.

Freezing or using a refrigerator does not cover poor tool work which contributes to bad turning and torn grain or sanding marks. Normally the piece will not warp, change shape or split unless a felling shake was present before you started turning, and you are away from the heart of the tree and must not be in the walls of the bowls. Not normally suitable in end grain if you are making a bowl, you need to try different species of wood with different densities.

Cyanoacrylate

Cyanoacrylate development in the past 30 years has been enormous, high-performance cyanoacrylate adhesives, some of which are now flexible and odourless to finish or glue timber pieces together comes in different thicknesses from very thin to thick, and in clear, black or brown.

Enhance your special piece of wood with thin superglue on project accessories, toy parts, shaker pegs, finials, knobs, eggs, fruit pieces, pen blanks, salt and pepper grinders, etc. It will be a permanent finish that will not wear as much, it is easy to apply and can be used as a filler. This advancement has made finishing a lot easier. Note: you need to sand your wood with fine abrasive before applying cyanoacrylate.

Sharpening HSS tools

The biggest problem about woodturning for the beginner, hobbyist or even professional is how to obtain a sharp edge on their turning tools. Most sharpening used to be done by holding the turning tool on a plate and was performed by hand. This did not work as well for gouges or give the ability to repeat the same grinding angle for each tool. To repeat a particular grind on individual tools, special jigs, angle gauges, holders for round or flat tools enable the turner to sharpen at exactly the same angle every time you use the grinder.

Better quality lathes

Turners now have a greater choice of both

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